



“The Vietnam War symbolized a new era of aerial technology, searing its way into public consciousness through the clatter of a helicopter or the bright yellow flame of a bomb explosion.”

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FIGHTING PHANTOM

The McDonnell F-4 Phantom II was the leading western fighter of the 1960s. During the Vietnam War it served with the US Navy, Marines, and Air Force. Phantoms were adapted for a variety of roles, including reconnaissance and electronic warfare.

AIR POWER IN ACTION

**WARS IN SOUTHEAST ASIA AND THE MIDDLE EAST
REVEALED BOTH THE POTENTIAL AND LIMITATIONS
OF AIR POWER IN THE JET AND MISSILE AGE**

FROM JANUARY TO MARCH 1968, more than 5,000 US Marines and South Vietnamese soldiers were besieged by communist forces in a combat base at Khe Sanh, South Vietnam. Fielded in their support was an array of air power such as only the world's most technologically advanced nation could deploy. Lockheed C-130 and Fairchild C-123 transports flew in supplies, by day and night under artillery and mortar fire, to the airstrip around which the base had been constructed. Three times a day “super gaggles” of transport helicopters, escorted by helicopter gunships and preceded by a wave of attack aircraft, ventured across hostile territory to isolated marine outposts around the base, taking in supplies and carrying out the wounded. Ground-attack aircraft battered the communist forces around the camp perimeter with high explosives and napalm – an average of 300 air strikes a day came in, roughly one every five minutes. Further out, B-52s reduced swathes of terrain to moonscape, dropping their formidable bombload from 7 miles (11 km) high.

The air operations often appeared desperate and chaotic. The weather, as it so often is in Vietnam, was dreadful for flying. The official marine history, describing operations around Khe Sanh, says: “Only those who have experienced the hazards of monsoon flying can fully appreciate the veritable madhouse that often exists when large numbers of aircraft are confined to restricted space beneath a low-hanging overcast sky.” Mortar and artillery bombardment of the airstrip became so hot that transports would land, taxi, and take off again without stopping, or not land at all and simply roll out their load from open cargo doors.

And yet the air operations worked. Fourteen years earlier, a French force besieged under similar circumstances by Vietnamese forces had been overrun at Dien Bien Phu, a catastrophe that

precipitated French withdrawal from their colonies in Southeast Asia. But despite dire predictions in the media, Khe Sanh held out and was eventually relieved. The difference was air power.

If air power could make a decisive difference to the outcome of a battle in Vietnam, why could it not in the end give the United States victory in the war? US air operations were astonishing in variety and quantity: for example, fleets of troop-transport helicopters providing mobility for the “air cavalry”; converted transports

